

IH02

Vedic Age and the 6th Century BCE Religious

Movements

Two to three questions a paper, and the pool is small and repeats. Mahajanapadas from the Anguttara Nikaya and from Panini (2013, 2016), Ajivika niyati (2013 and again 2024), Jain Anekantavada and Syadvada (2021), Matsya capital Viratnagar (2016). Note the Rajasthan hooks - Matsya, Shivi and the Malavas.

Two blocks in one chapter. First the Vedic texts and the society they describe, then the sixth-century BCE churn that produced Jainism, Buddhism and the Ajivikas. RPSC's taste here is precise and textual - which mandala, which Brahmana belongs to which Veda, which Mahajanapada had which capital, which teacher taught niyati.

Vedic Age & the 6th Century BCE

The four Vedas

- Rigveda - 10 mandalas, 1028 hymns
- Samaveda - musical chants
- Yajurveda - sacrificial formulae, part prose
- Atharvaveda - charms, the Brahmvada

Later Vedic literature

- Brahmanas - ritual prose
- Aranyakas - forest texts
- Upanishads - philosophy
- Six Vedangas

Society & polity

- Sabha, Samiti, Vidatha, Gana
- Purohita, Senani, Gramani, Vrajapati
- Varna from the Purusha Sukta
- Early = cattle & gavishti; Later = iron, PGW, big sacrifices

Mahajanapadas

- 16 in the Anguttara Nikaya & Bhagavati Sutra
- Panini's Ashtadhyayi - Yaudheyas, Salvas
- Matsya - Viratnagar (Bairat)
- Shivi - Madhyamika (Nagari)

Rise of Magadha

- Haryanka - Bimbisara, Ajatashatru, Udayin
- Shishunaga
- Nanda - Mahapadma, Dhana Nanda
- Maurya

Heterodox sects

- Jainism - Mahavira, Triratna, Anekantavada
- Buddhism - four truths, eightfold path, 4 councils
- Ajivika - Makkhali Gosala, niyati
- Charvaka materialism; Sanjaya's Ajnana

The four Vedas - learn each by its one-line identity

Start with the simplest possible handle. Each Veda has one identity, and that identity is what gets matched. Rigveda is hymns of praise. Samaveda is music. Yajurveda is the formulae you mutter while performing the sacrifice. Atharvaveda is charms and spells - the folk religion. Fix those four and the matching question is done.

Veda - content - the fact that gets asked

Veda	Principal content	Remember
Rigveda	Hymns of praise	10 mandalas, 1028 hymns (1017 + 11 Valakhilya); oldest text

Veda	Principal content	Remember
Samaveda	Musical chants	The earliest source of Indian music
Yajurveda	Sacrificial formulae	The only Veda partly in prose; Shukla (Vajasaneyi) and Krishna (Taittiriya) branches
Atharvaveda	Charms, spells, popular belief	Also called the Brahaveda; recensions Shaunaka and Paippalada

- Mandalas II to VII are the 'family books' and are the oldest; mandalas I and X are the latest additions.
- Mandala IX is devoted entirely to Soma.
- The Gayatri mantra is in Mandala III, addressed to the solar deity Savitri, and ascribed to Vishvamitra.
- The Purusha Sukta (Rigveda X.90) carries the earliest reference to the four varnas.
- The Nadistuti Sukta of Mandala X lists the rivers.
- Sindhu is the river named most often; Saraswati is called naditama, best of rivers. Ganga occurs once, Yamuna thrice.

YAAD RAKHO

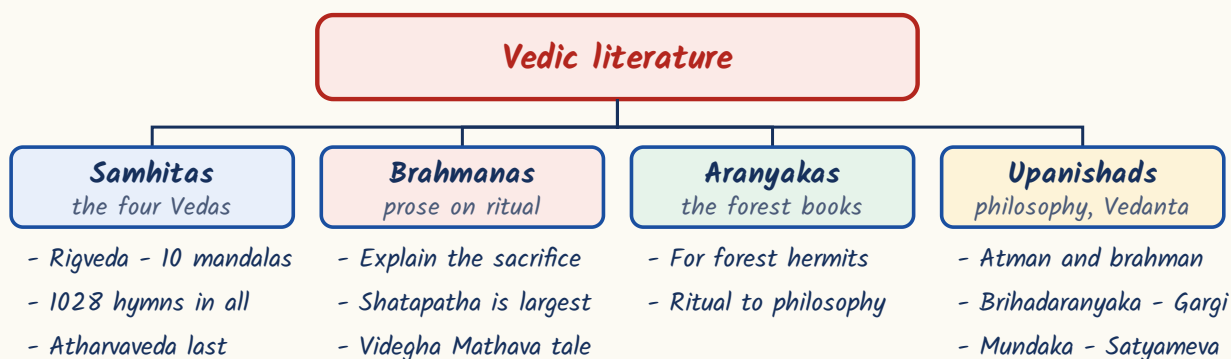
Number the special mandalas - 3 for Gayatri, 9 for Soma, 10 for both the Purusha Sukta and the Nadistuti. Three, nine, ten. And the oldest core is 2 to 7.

One event from the Rigveda is asked by name. The Battle of Ten Kings, the Dasharajna, was fought on the Parushni - the modern Ravi. Sudas of the Bharatas won it, with the priest Vasishtha on his side, against a confederacy backed by Vishvamitra.

Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads, Vedangas

After the Vedas came layers of commentary. Brahmanas explain the ritual in prose. Aranyakas are the 'forest books' for those who withdrew from village life. Upanishads are philosophy - atman, brahman, karma, rebirth. The Vedangas are the six technical limbs you need in order to use the Vedas correctly.

The layers of Vedic literature



Brahmana to Veda - a standing matching question

Brahmana	Attached to
Aitareya, Kaushitaki	Rigveda
Panchavimsha (Tandya), Jaiminiya	Samaveda
Shatapatha - the largest of them all	Shukla Yajurveda
Taittiriya	Krishna Yajurveda
Gopatha	Atharvaveda

- The Shatapatha Brahmana tells of Videgha Mathava's eastward migration to the Sadanira (Gandak) - our evidence for Vedic culture spreading into the middle Ganga plain.
- Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya are the oldest Upanishads.
- 'Satyameva Jayate' below the State Emblem of India comes from the Mundaka Upanishad.
- Yajnavalkya's dialogues with Gargi and with Maitreyi are in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad.

The six Vedangas

Vedanga	Subject	Associated name
Shiksha	Phonetics	-
Kalpa	Ritual	-
Vyakarana	Grammar	Panini's Ashtadhyayi
Nirukta	Etymology	Yaska
Chhanda	Metrics	Pingala
Jyotisha	Astronomy	-

- The negative-framed question here is always a Vedanga mismatch - Chhanda is metrics, NOT etymology; Nirukta is etymology and it is Yaska's.
- Aranyakas sit between the Brahmanas and the Upanishads and are meant for forest-dwelling students, not for householders.

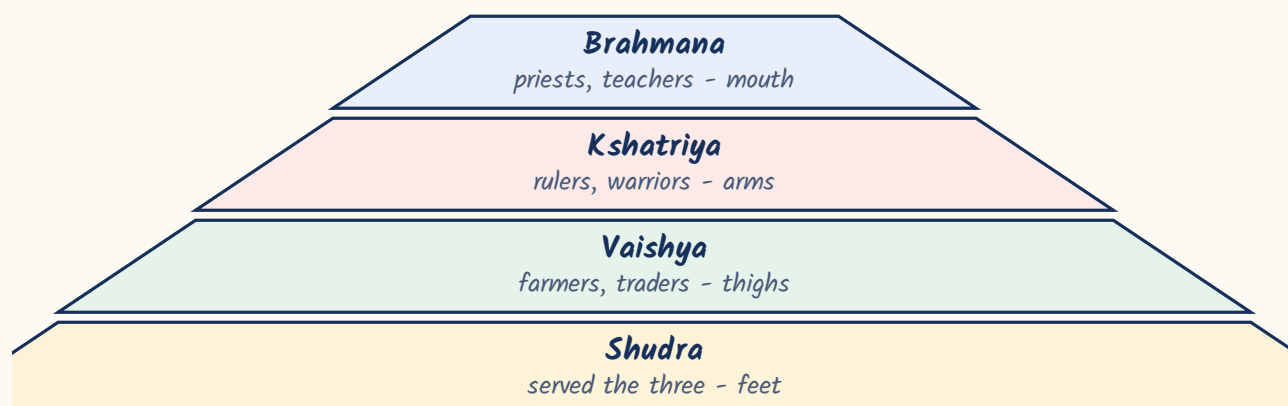
Early Vedic against Later Vedic - the comparison that answers half the questions

Almost every Vedic statement question is really asking, is this early or later. So build the contrast once and use it everywhere. Early Vedic is pastoral, tribal, Punjab-centred, no taxes, no rigid caste. Later Vedic is agricultural, territorial, Ganga-Yamuna doab-centred, with iron, big sacrifices and a hardening varna order.

Early Vedic (c. 1500–1000 BCE) vs Later Vedic (c. 1000–600 BCE)

Early Vedic	Later Vedic
Rigveda only	Later Vedas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads
Sapta-Sindhu, the Punjab region	Ganga-Yamuna doab and eastward
Pastoral - wealth counted in cattle	Agricultural - land becomes the wealth
Copper and bronze	Iron, called shyama ayas or krishna ayas
Ochre Coloured Pottery horizon	Painted Grey Ware (PGW)
Sabha, Samiti, Vidatha and Gana all active	Sabha and Samiti weaken; Vidatha disappears
No regular tax; bali a voluntary offering	Bali, bhaga and shulka become regular dues
Varna present but flexible	Varna hardens; the Shudra's position worsens
Simple household rituals	Rajasuya, ashvamedha, vajapeya - grand sacrifices

The varna order, as the Purusha Sukta puts it



- *Gavishti* - literally 'search for cows' - is the Rigvedic word for war. Cattle were the unit of wealth, and the king is called *gopati* or *gopa janasya*.
- Chief officials of the early period: *Purohita*, *Senani*, *Gramani* and *Vrajapati*.
- *Vidatha* is the OLDEST of the Vedic assemblies. *Sabha* and *Samiti* both appear in the *Rigveda*.
- The word *gotra* appears first in the *Atharvaveda*, not in the *Rigveda*.
- The four *ashramas* are listed in full only in later Vedic and post-Vedic texts.
- Early Vedic society had *varna* but NOT a rigid birth-based caste system with untouchability - that option is always false.
- Equally false for the early period: 'a regular system of taxation existed and *bali* was a compulsory levy'.

The sixteen Mahajanapadas - and the three Rajasthan entries

By the sixth century BCE north India had settled into sixteen large states. The list of sixteen comes from the Buddhist *Anguttara Nikaya* and from the Jain *Bhagavati Sutra* - so it is not a Buddhist list alone, and RPSC has tested exactly that point. *Panini's Ashtadhyayi*, a grammar, separately names a large number of *janapadas*, including the *Yaudheyas* and the *Salvas*, which are NOT among the sixteen.

Mahajanapada to capital - part I

Mahajanapada	Capital
Magadha	Girivraja / Rajagriha, later Pataliputra
Kosala	Shravasti
Kashi	Varanasi
Anga	Champa
Vatsa	Kaushambi
Avanti	Ujjain in the north, Mahishmati in the south

Mahajanapada	Capital
Vajji	Vaishali
Malla	Kushinara and Pava

Mahajanapada to capital - part 2

Mahajanapada	Capital
Matsya	Viratnagar - modern Bairat, Jaipur district
Surasena	Mathura
Gandhara	Taxila
Kamboja	Rajapura
Chedi	Shuktimati
Assaka	Potali
Kuru	Indraprastha
Panchala	Ahichhatra and Kampilya

The Rajasthan connection - RPSC will always take this exit

- Matsya Mahajanapada covered the Jaipur-Alwar-Bharatpur tract. Its capital Viratnagar is modern Bairat in Jaipur district - the same Bairat that later gave us Ashoka's edicts.
- The Shivi janapada had its capital at Madhyamika, modern Nagari near Chittorgarh.
- Malava coins have been found in very large numbers at Nagar in Tonk district.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - the list of sixteen Mahajanapadas is given in the Anguttara Nikaya. RAS Pre 2016 - the capital of the Matsya Mahajanapada was Viratnagar.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2016 also ran the Panini set: Ashtadhyayi refers to many janapadas including the Yaudheyas and the Salvakas (true); the list of sixteen occurs only in Buddhist literature (false - the Jain Bhagavati Sutra has it too); Avanti had two capitals (true).

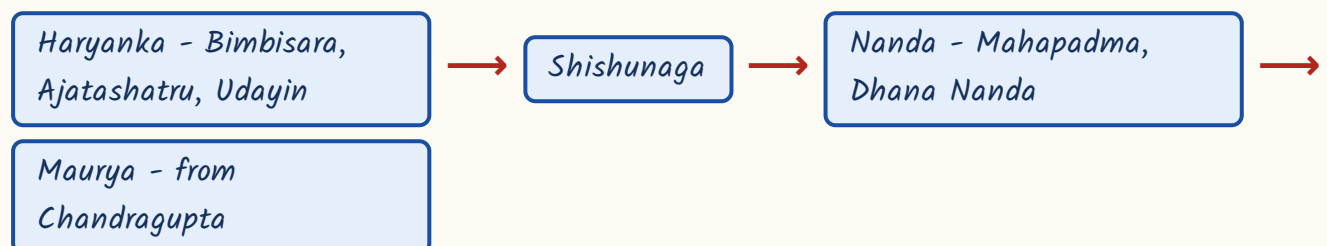
TRAP

Yaudheya is NOT one of the sixteen Mahajanapadas. It comes from Panini. RPSC has used it as the odd-one-out option, and it is tempting precisely because Rajasthan students know the name.

Rise of Magadha - the dynasty chain

Out of the sixteen, one state swallowed the rest. Magadha won because of geography and iron. It sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain, controlled the iron of south Bihar, had elephants from the forests, and its capitals - first Rajagriha ringed by hills, then Pataliputra at the meeting of the Ganga and the Son - were natural fortresses. Learn the reasons; they come as an assertion-reason or a statement set.

Magadhan dynasties in order - an ordering question every few years



- Bimbisara expanded by matrimonial alliances and annexed Anga.
- Ajatashatru fought the Vajjis using the rathamusala, a mace-fitted chariot, and the mahashilakantaka, a stone-throwing engine.
- Udayin founded Pataliputra at the Ganga-Son confluence.
- Mahapadma Nanda is called Ekarat and Sarvakshatrantaka - 'destroyer of all kshatriyas' - in the Puranas.
- Dhana Nanda was on the throne when Alexander invaded the north-west in 326 BCE; he was later overthrown by Chandragupta Maurya.

YAAD RAKHO

Ordering mnemonic for Magadha - Ha-Shi-Na-Mau. Haryanka, Shishunaga, Nanda, Maurya. The exam gives them jumbled; you just recite the four syllables.

Jainism - Mahavira, the vows, the doctrines, the councils

Jainism was not founded by Mahavira. He is the twenty-fourth Tirthankara; Parshvanatha was the twenty-third and lived about 250 years before him. Rishabhadeva, the first, is even mentioned in the Rigveda. Mahavira's work was to tighten and organise what already existed.

- Mahavira - born c. 540 BCE at Kundagrama near Vaishali. Father Siddhartha of the Jnatika clan, mother Trishala.
- He attained kaivalya, omniscience, at the age of 42 on the bank of the Rijupalika.
- He died at Pavapuri.
- Parshvanatha gave four vows - ahimsa, satya, asteya, aparigraha. Mahavira added the fifth, brahmacharya.
- Triratna, the three jewels: right faith, right knowledge, right conduct.
- Anekantavada - reality has many aspects. Syadvada - every judgement is only conditionally true, 'may be', expressed in a seven-fold predication.

Jain councils and the split

Council	Venue	Presided by	Outcome
First	Pataliputra	Sthulabhadra	The 12 Angas compiled
Second	Vallabhi	Devardhi Kshamashramana	The canon finally written down in Ardhamagadhi

- The sects: Digambara, the sky-clad, associated with Bhadrabahu; Shvetambara, the white-clad, associated with Sthulabhadra.
- Jain literature is in Prakrit, specifically Ardhamagadhi.
- Royal patrons include Chandragupta Maurya (Jain tradition), Kharavela of Kalinga, and the Chalukya and Ganga rulers of the south.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - Anekantavada is the doctrine that reality has many aspects and Syadvada that every proposition is true only in a conditional sense; both are Jain, NOT Buddhist. That third statement was the trap.

TRAP

Bhadrabahu goes with the DIGAMBARA sect, Sthulabhadra with the Shvetambara. The wrong-pair question in this chapter is nearly always 'Bhadrabahu - Shvetambara'. Also note: the first Jain council at Pataliputra was under Sthulabhadra, not Bhadrabahu, because Bhadrabahu had gone south.

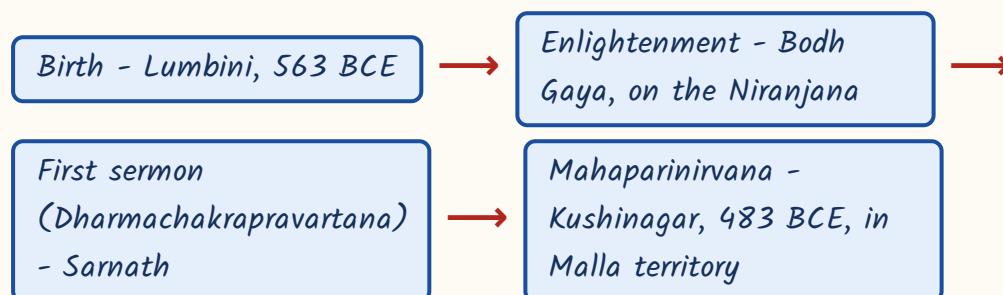
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - on 3 October 2024 the Union Cabinet granted classical language status to Pali and Prakrit, along with Marathi, Bengali and Assamese. Pali is the language of the Buddhist Tripitaka and Ardhamagadhi Prakrit that of the Jain canon, so the decision is a ready-made hook for a question that pairs a language with a religious literature.

Buddhism - life, doctrine, councils, texts

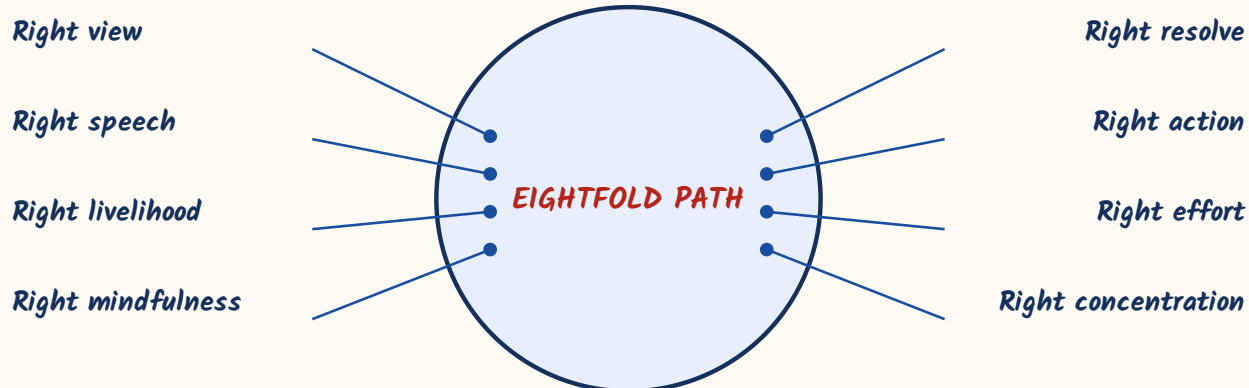
For the exam, Buddhism breaks into four blocks: the four places of the Buddha's life, the doctrine in its numbered form, the four councils, and the texts. Take them in that order and nothing overlaps.

The four great places of the Buddha's life

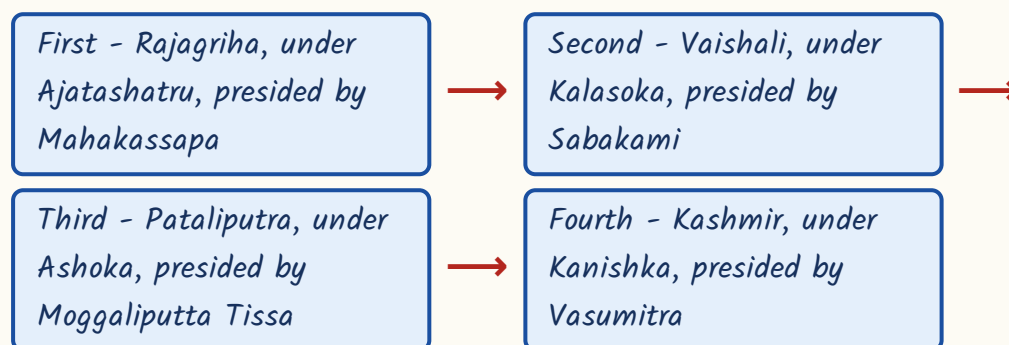


- Four Noble Truths: there is suffering; suffering has a cause; suffering can end; there is a path to ending it.
- The Eightfold Path (ashtangika marga): right view, right resolve, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.
- That path is the middle path - between sensual indulgence on one side and severe self-torture on the other.
- Buddhism denies the authority of the Vedas and the necessity of sacrifice, and it was preached in Pali, the people's language.
- The three jewels of Buddhism: Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha.

The Eightfold Path (ashtangika marga)



The four Buddhist councils - venue, patron, president



- The Third Council compiled the Abhidhamma Pitaka, the last of the three baskets.
- The Fourth Council in Kashmir produced the Mahavibhasha and marks the Hinayana-Mahayana split.
- Tripitaka - Vinaya Pitaka (monastic rules), Sutta Pitaka (sermons), Abhidhamma Pitaka (philosophy). All in Pali.
- The Jataka stories, tales of the Buddha's previous births, sit in the Khuddaka Nikaya of the Sutta Pitaka.
- The Milindapanho records the dialogue between the Indo-Greek king Menander (Milinda) and the monk Nagasena.
- Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa are the Buddhist chronicles of Sri Lanka, in Pali.
- Divyavadana is a SANSKRIT text and is not part of the Pali Tripitaka.

The Tripitaka - the three baskets



TRAP

The first council was at RAJAGRIHA under Ajatashatru, not at Vaishali. Vaishali is the second, under Kalasoka. RPSC has planted 'first council at Vaishali under Ajatashatru' inside a statement set - one clause right, one wrong.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the Piprahwa gem relics, excavated in 1898 from a stupa near the Buddha's Shakya homeland, were put up for sale by Sotheby's Hong Kong in May 2025. India objected on legal and cultural grounds, the auction was halted, and the relics were handed back to India at the end of July 2025 - a repatriation after 127 years. A likely current-affairs hook that lands on this chapter's content.

Jainism against Buddhism - the classic comparison

Both were born in the same century, in the same region, out of the same discontent with Vedic ritual and brahmanical dominance. Both used the people's language, both rejected the Vedas, both admitted women and all varnas. What separates them is severity - Jainism goes to the extreme of ahimsa and austerity, Buddhism deliberately takes the middle path. Learn the differences, because the similarities are what makes the wrong options plausible.

Jainism vs Buddhism

Jainism	Buddhism
Mahavira, 24th Tirthankara; the faith is older	Gautama Buddha is the founder
Five vows, brahmacharya added by Mahavira	Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path
Extreme ahimsa and severe austerity; sallekhana	The middle path; austerity explicitly rejected
Accepts the soul (jiva) in everything, including matter	Denies a permanent soul (anatta)
Anekantavada and Syadvada	Pratityasamutpada - dependent origination
Language Ardhamagadhi Prakrit	Language Pali
Two councils - Pataliputra, Vallabhi	Four councils - Rajagriha, Vaishali, Pataliputra, Kashmir
Sects: Digambara and Shvetambara	Sects: Hinayana, Mahayana, later Vajrayana
Stayed within India; strong in Gujarat, Rajasthan, Karnataka	Spread across Asia; declined in India

One line to hold the whole contrast - Jainism says conquer the body, Buddhism says balance it. Every doctrinal difference in that table flows from it.

The other heterodox schools - small topic, disproportionate marks

Besides Mahavira and the Buddha there were four more famous teachers in the sixth century BCE. RPSC likes them because they are easy to confuse. The Ajivika question in particular is a documented repeat - it came in 2013 and came back in 2024.

Teacher to doctrine - learn this table as a unit

Teacher	School / doctrine	One-word handle
Makkhali Gosala	Ajivika - the doctrine of niyati, destiny	Fatalism
Purana Kassapa	Akriyavada - action has no moral consequence	Non-action

Teacher	School / doctrine	One-word handle
Ajita Kesakambalin	Materialism - man is made of the four elements	Materialism
Pakudha Kachchayana	Eternal indivisible categories	Atomism
Sanjaya Belatthiputta	Ajnana - knowledge of the ultimate is impossible	Scepticism
Brihaspati (traced to)	Charvaka / Lokayata materialism	Lokayata

Understand niyati before you memorise it. The Ajivikas held that everything is already fixed by destiny. Effort changes nothing; a soul simply runs its allotted course through births until release comes on its own. That is why Ajivika is labelled fatalism. The sect had real royal backing - Ashoka gave them cave dwellings in the Barabar hills and his grandson Dasharatha gave the Nagarjuni hill caves, which you will meet again in the Mauryan chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024, repeating 2013 - the doctrine of niyati or destiny was the central teaching of the Ajivika sect, founded by Makkhali Gosala. In 2013 the same fact came as a teacher-to-doctrine matching set with Ajita Kesakambalin (materialism), Pakudha Kachchayana (atomism) and Sanjaya Belatthiputta (scepticism).

REVISION RECAP

1. Rigveda - 10 mandalas, 1028 hymns; family books II-VII oldest; I and X latest; IX all Soma.
2. Gayatri in Mandala III to Savitri, by Vishvamitra; Purusha Sukta X.90 gives the four varnas; Nadistuti lists rivers.
3. Sindhu named most often; Saraswati is naditama; Ganga once, Yamuna thrice; Dasharajna on the Parushni, Sudas won.

4. Samaveda - music. Yajurveda - formulae, part prose, Shukla and Krishna. Atharvaveda - charms, the Brahmvveda.
5. Shatapatha is the largest Brahmana (Shukla Yajurveda) and carries the Videgha Mathava migration to the Sadanira.
6. Aitareya-Rigveda, Panchavimsha-Samaveda, Taittiriya-Krishna Yajurveda, Gopatha-Atharvaveda.
7. Satyameva Jayate from the Mundaka Upanishad; Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya oldest; Yajnavalkya-Gargi-Maitreyi in Brihadaranyaka.
8. Vedangas - Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakarana (Panini), Nirukta (Yaska), Chhanda (Pingala), Jyotisha.
9. Early Vedic - pastoral, gavishti for war, Vidatha oldest assembly, bali voluntary, no untouchability.
10. Later Vedic - iron as shyama/krishna ayas, Painted Grey Ware, rajasuya-ashvamedha-vajapeya, gotra first in the Atharvaveda.
11. Sixteen Mahajanapadas listed in the Anguttara Nikaya and the Jain Bhagavati Sutra; Panini separately names the Yaudheyas and Salvas, which are not among the sixteen.
12. Rajasthan entries - Matsya, capital Viratnagar (Bairat, Jaipur); Shivi, capital Madhyamika (Nagari, Chittorgarh); Malava coins at Nagar, Tonk.
13. Avanti had two capitals - Ujjain and Mahishmati. Vajji - Vaishali. Vatsa - Kaushambi. Anga - Champa. Chedi - Shuktimati.
14. Magadha order: Haryanka, Shishunaga, Nanda, Maurya. Ajatashatru's rathamusala and mahashilakantaka; Udayin founded Pataliputra; Mahapadma Nanda = Ekarat and Sarvakshatrantaka; Dhana Nanda ruled at Alexander's invasion of 326 BCE.
15. Mahavira - Kundagrama near Vaishali, Jnatrika clan, kaivalya at 42 on the Rijupalika, died at Pavapuri; added brahmacharya.
16. Jain councils - Pataliputra under Sthulabhadra, Vallabhi under Devardhi Kshamashramana; Digambara-Bhadrabahu, Shvetambara-Sthulabhadra.
17. Buddha - Lumbini 563 BCE, Bodh Gaya, first sermon Sarnath, mahaparinirvana Kushinagar 483 BCE.
18. Councils - Rajagriha/Ajatashatru/Mahakassapa, Vaishali/Kalasoka/Sabakami, Pataliputra/Ashoka/Moggaliputta Tissa, Kashmir/Kanishka/Vasumitra.
19. Tripitaka in Pali; Jatakas in the Khuddaka Nikaya; Divyavadana is Sanskrit and outside the Tripitaka.
20. Makkhali Gosala - Ajivika, niyati. Purana Kassapa - akriyavada. Ajita Kesakambalin - materialism. Pakudha - atomism. Sanjaya - Ajnana.